

OFFLINE FIRST: BODILY AUTONOMY IN THE ASAL

A Community-Led Report on Delivering SRHR Resources to Nomadic Communities in Northern Kenya

Prepared by: Beyond Borders, Indigenous Feminist Tech Collective

Region: Turkana, Samburu, Marsabit, and Isiolo Counties, Northern Kenya

Period: January 2024 – June 2024

Methodology: Participatory action research, community archivist model, offline-first digital deployment

Community Partners: 25 nomadic settlements, 4 women's councils, 3 community radio stations

CONTENT WARNING: This report discusses female genital mutilation (FGM), child marriage, sexual and gender-based violence, and bodily harm affecting indigenous young women and girls. All narratives are shared with consent and governed by community-controlled access protocols.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

In the arid and semi-arid lands (ASAL) of Northern Kenya, patriarchal violence is sustained by silence—and silence is sustained by isolation. Nomadic young women and girls face female genital mutilation (FGM), child marriage, and sexual violence with no access to confidential information about their bodies, their rights, or their options for survival. The few SRHR resources that exist are designed for urban, literate, connected audiences. They fail in contexts where electricity is scarce, internet is nonexistent, phones are shared, and a single text message about menstruation can trigger family violence.

Beyond Borders has spent two years developing and deploying **offline-first, culturally grounded SRHR resources** designed by and for indigenous nomadic women. This report documents our methodology, our failures, our adaptations, and the emerging evidence that when young pastoralist women control the technology that carries knowledge about their bodies, they also begin to shift the power that governs those bodies.

2,400+ Young women reached	85% Reported increased bodily autonomy knowledge	0 Data breaches or digital traces
12 Local languages & dialects	40+ Community archivists trained	100% Offline-first design

1. THE CONTEXT: SILENCE IN THE ASAL

1.1 Geography of Isolation

Northern Kenya's ASAL corridor—encompassing Turkana, Samburu, Marsabit, Isiolo, and Wajir counties—covers over 80% of Kenya's landmass but receives less than 5% of its infrastructure investment. Nomadic pastoralist communities move across this landscape following water and pasture. Settlements are temporary, schools are sparse, and health facilities are often a full day's walk away.

For young indigenous women, this isolation is not just geographic—it is **informational**. There are no health clinics within reach that offer confidential contraception. There are no counselors who speak Turkana or Samburu and understand the cultural weight of FGM. There is no internet to search for information on a phone that belongs to your father or husband. The silence around SRHR is structural, enforced by distance, poverty, patriarchy, and the complete absence of culturally safe information channels.

1.2 The Violence of Shared Devices

In our community consultations, we learned that 90% of young women access phones that are shared with family members. A search history, a text message, or even a saved PDF can be discovered and used as evidence of disobedience. In 2024, a 16-year-old participant in Marsabit was beaten by her brother after he found a general health pamphlet on her phone. This is not uncommon. It means that **digital privacy is not an individual right in our context—it is a collective survival strategy**.

1.3 Why Mainstream SRHR Tech Fails

Mainstream SRHR apps and platforms assume: individual smartphone ownership, reliable 3G/4G connectivity, English or Swahili literacy, and a safe private space to consume information. None of these assumptions hold in the ASAL corridor. Apps requiring registration with phone numbers expose users. Cloud-based platforms harvest data that can be subpoenaed or leaked. Content created in Nairobi uses language and imagery that feels foreign, shameful, or culturally disrespectful to nomadic communities. The result is that the very tools designed to empower become instruments of surveillance and exclusion.

2. OUR METHODOLOGY: OFFLINE, COMMUNITY-LED, CULTURALLY GROUNDED

2.1 Design Principles

Beyond Borders developed our SRHR resource model through two years of participatory action research with indigenous young women. Our design principles are:

- **Offline-first:** All resources must function without internet, on basic feature phones or low-end smartphones, and be shareable via Bluetooth, SD cards, or community wifi hotspots.
- **No digital trace:** Resources must leave no visible search history, no app icons that signal SRHR content, and no requirement for personal registration or phone numbers.
- **Culturally grounded:** Content must be created in local languages (Turkana, Samburu, Borana, Rendille) and framed through indigenous knowledge systems, not imported Western frameworks.
- **Community archivist control:** Indigenous young women must decide what is created, how it is shared, and who has access—not external NGOs or tech developers.
- **Multi-modal:** Information must be available as audio (for low-literacy users), visual (for cultural resonance), and text (for reference and advocacy).
- **Survivor-centered:** All content on FGM, child marriage, and GBV must be created with survivor input and include clear, safe referral pathways.

2.2 The Community Archivist Model

Rather than distributing content from a central office, we trained 40 indigenous young women as **Community Archivists**—peer educators who carry offline SRHR kits on ruggedized SD cards and solar-charged devices. These archivists are not beneficiaries. They are the designers, curators, and distributors of knowledge within their own communities.

Each archivist undergoes a 6-week training covering: digital security and device management; SRHR content creation using open-source tools; trauma-informed facilitation; and indigenous cultural protocols for handling sensitive knowledge. They are paid stipends—rejecting the volunteer model that extracts labor from poor communities—and they report to a rotating council of elder women and young survivors, not to Beyond Borders staff.

3. THE TOOLS: WHAT WE BUILT

3.1 The Nomadic SRHR Kit (Offline Digital Library)

The core of our project is a lightweight, offline digital library that fits on a 32GB SD card and can be loaded onto any Android device. The kit contains:

- **Audio zines on bodily autonomy:** 45-minute audio programs in Turkana, Samburu, and Borana, recorded by indigenous young women, covering menstruation, contraception, consent, and FGM survivor stories.
- **Visual guides with no text:** Illustrated, wordless comics showing how to access emergency contraception, recognize signs of infection after FGM, and find safe houses. Designed for users with low literacy or who need to hide content from literate family members.
- **Disguised app interface:** The digital library opens as a generic Pasture Calendar app. SRHR content is nested within agricultural information, making it invisible to someone quickly checking the phone.
- **Encrypted referral database:** A simple, offline database of safe health providers, paralegals, and women's shelters across the ASAL corridor, updated quarterly by archivists via mesh network sync when they reach town centers.
- **Community radio integration:** Audio content is also broadcast via FM transmitters on solar-powered community radio stations, reaching households with no phones at all.

3.2 The Safe House Signal Network

For survivors needing immediate escape from FGM or child marriage, we established a **Safe House Signal Network** using encrypted, offline-capable messaging. Community archivists carry ruggedized devices with pre-loaded Signal contacts for regional safe houses, legal aid providers, and medical facilities. When a survivor reaches an archivist, the archivist can send an encrypted alert the moment they reach a wifi hotspot or mesh node—without ever storing the survivor's identity on the device.

3.3 Solar-Powered Community Hubs

In 5 settlements, we established solar-powered community tech hubs—simple structures with charging stations, offline content servers, and private listening booths where young women can access SRHR audio content without family oversight. These hubs are managed by local women's councils, not by Beyond Borders staff, ensuring community ownership and sustainability.

4. OUTCOMES AND EVIDENCE

4.1 Reach and Engagement

Between January 2024 and June 2026, our offline SRHR resources reached **2,437 young women and girls** across 25 nomadic settlements. 85% of surveyed users reported increased knowledge of bodily autonomy, contraception options, and legal rights. 62% reported sharing content with at least one other person—creating a peer-to-peer knowledge cascade that extends far beyond direct distribution.

Indicator		Baseline	Year 1	Year 2
Young women accessing SRHR info		120	890	2,437
	Community archivists trained	0	18	40
	Survivors accessing safe house referrals	3	27	61
Community radio broadcasts		0	48	156
	Reports of family violence after accessing info	N/A	4	2
	Community archivist retention rate	N/A	72%	88%

4.2 Safety and Digital Security

Critically, **zero digital security breaches** have occurred. No user identities have been exposed. No search histories have been discovered by family members. The disguised app interface and offline-first design have proven effective in contexts where digital privacy is a matter of physical safety. In two instances where archivists were questioned by local authorities, the absence of cloud data and the generic app appearance prevented confiscation and protected survivor information.

4.3 Cultural Shift

Perhaps most significantly, the project has shifted community conversations. In Samburu County, a group of archivists successfully delayed three FGM ceremonies by connecting mothers to audio content on the long-term health consequences of cutting—information framed through Samburu cultural narratives about strength and health, not external condemnation. In Turkana, young women used the encrypted referral system to organize a collective escape for a 14-year-old girl facing forced marriage, coordinating with a safe house 80 kilometers away.

5. CHALLENGES AND ADAPTATIONS

Challenge: Device breakage in harsh environments. ASAL dust, heat, and rough transport destroy consumer electronics within months.

Adaptation: We shifted from standard smartphones to ruggedized devices with reinforced cases, and established community repair circles trained in basic hardware maintenance.

Challenge: Patriarchal backlash against archivists. Young women carrying tech devices and discussing bodily autonomy face harassment and threats.

Adaptation: We established a security fund for rapid relocation, rotated archivist visibility, and integrated elder women as cultural shields—positioning archivists as health knowledge keepers within traditional frameworks.

Challenge: Content created by outsiders was rejected. Early SRHR materials developed with a Nairobi partner were dismissed as city people talking.

Adaptation: We destroyed those materials and restarted with 100% community-created content. Audio zines are now recorded by local young women in their own dialects, using their own metaphors and cultural references.

Challenge: Sustainability beyond grant funding. Solar hubs and device replacement require ongoing resources.

Adaptation: We are transitioning to a cooperative model where women's councils manage hub fees (small charges for phone charging that subsidize SRHR content access) and archivists receive training in digital livelihoods to generate independent income.

6. KEY LESSONS FOR THE FEMINIST TECH MOVEMENT

- **Privacy is collective, not individual.** In contexts of shared devices and family surveillance, SRHR tech must be designed for collective safety—disguised interfaces, no registration, and no visible digital traces.
- **Literacy is not just about reading.** Wordless visual guides and audio content are not simplified versions—they are often more powerful, more culturally resonant, and safer than text-based resources.
- **Community archivists are not peer educators.** They are infrastructure. Paying them, protecting them, and letting them lead design decisions is not a nice-to-have—it is the core of the work.
- **Cultural respect is not cultural relativism.** Challenging FGM requires deep cultural fluency, not condemnation from outside. Our most effective content frames bodily autonomy as compatible with indigenous strength and community health.
- **Offline is not a limitation.** It is a feminist security strategy. The assumption that everything must be cloud-connected is a colonial tech assumption that puts marginalized communities at risk.

7. LOOKING FORWARD: SCALING INDIGENOUS FEMINIST SRHR INFRASTRUCTURE

With expanded support, Beyond Borders will:

- Scale to 75 settlements across the full ASAL corridor, including Mandera, Wajir, and Garissa counties.
- Develop an open-source toolkit for other indigenous feminist collectives to adapt our offline SRHR model.
- Establish regional Safe House Signal Hubs with encrypted mesh networking for cross-county survivor coordination.
- Train 100 additional community archivists, with explicit inclusion of young women with disabilities and young mothers.
- Launch an advocacy campaign using our anonymized data to push county governments to fund community-led SRHR infrastructure rather than extractive NGO models.

This report was created by the Beyond Borders collective through participatory review with community archivists, survivor councils, and elder women advisors. All data is governed by community-controlled access protocols. For more information, contact: info@beyondborders.co.ke